



INSTITUTE FOR RETROACTIVE TECHNOLOGICAL PANIC (IRTP)

— White Paper No. 47-B —

On the Repeated Historical Failure to Remember Previous Machines

Project Codename: *PROMETHEUS AMNESIA INITIATIVE (PAI)*

HISTORY
REASSESSED.
DANGER
DECLARED.

★ EXECUTIVE SUMMARY ★

This white paper addresses the recurring institutional panic in which contemporary observers declare a new machine to be unprecedented, socially destabilizing, economically incomprehensible, and fundamentally incompatible with existing economic theory—despite identical claims being made for at least the last 500 years, and arguably since the controlled use of fire.

The Institute for Retroactive Technological Panic (IRTP) has identified a persistent cognitive phenomenon, herein designated Technological Exceptionalism Recurrence Disorder (TERD), in which each generation insists that its machines are uniquely world-ending while simultaneously using electricity, industrial agriculture, and antibiotics without comment.

This paper formally rejects the claim that economic theory “never accounted for machines that do weeks of human work in seconds,” on the grounds that this is precisely what the steam engine, printing press, mechanized loom, tractor, assembly line, calculator, and computer were specifically invented to do, and in fact did.

The present document therefore proposes a comprehensive framework for remembering things that already happened.



BUREAU OF HISTORICAL
RISK ASSESSMENT
“HINDSIGHT IS OUR MANDATE”

EMERGENCY HEARING
DOCKET 47-B

**BACKDATED
HAZARD**

SUBJECT: ALL MACHINES
EVER INVENTED
(TO DATE)

MUSEUM OF
QUESTIONABLE
PROGRESS
EST. 1857

ALERT! ALERT! ALERT!
HISTORICAL OBJECTS UNDER REVIEW

CONTROLLED USE
OF FIRE

PRINTING PRESS
(c. 1440)

STEAM ENGINE
(c. 1769)

⚠ FIRE
PRIMORDIAL
COMBUSTION
HAZARD

⚠ INFORMATION
MULTIPLICATION
RISK

⚠ UNNATURAL
FORCE
GENERATION

DANGER:
OLD TECHNOLOGIES
MAY HAVE CAUSED
UNFORESEEN
CONSEQUENCES.
PROCEED WITH
HISTORICAL CAUTION.

RISK REVIEW
FORM 12.7B
URGENT

TODAY'S HEARING:

- ✓ ARE STEAM ENGINES EVIL?
 - ✓ DID THE PRINTING PRESS CAUSE CHAOS?
 - ✓ WAS FIRE A MISTAKE?
 - ✓ CAN WE SUE THE PAST?
- ALL ITEMS SUBJECT TO
RETROACTIVE LIABILITY.

IF WE DON'T REMEMBER HISTORY, WE ARE CONDEMNED TO REDECLARE IT DANGEROUS.

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1. HISTORICAL PRECEDENT FAILURE ANALYSIS (HPFA)

Project Codename: PROMETHEUS AMNESIA INITIATIVE (PAI)

RETROACTIVE
THREAT LEVEL:

SEVERE

ALARM IN EFFECT

1.1 The Fire Event (Pre-Industrial Automation Phase 0)

Fire allowed one human to perform the work of:

- Multiple hours of chewing (cooking)
- Several days of walking (land clearing)
- Entire winters of shivering (heating)
- Manual darkness removal (lighting)

Conclusion: Fire was the original labor-replacing technology and should have triggered mass economic panic under the “machines doing work faster than humans” theory. Instead, civilization occurred.

EXHIBIT A-1
FIRE: THE FIRST
SUSPICIOUS DEVICE

PRE-INDUSTRIAL
AUTOMATION
PHASE 0
(VERY OLD)

DANGER:
UNCONTROLLED HEAT
GENERATING DEVICE

DANGER

FIRE
HAS CAUSED
UNFORESEEN
CONSEQUENCES.
PROCEED WITH
HISTORICAL
CAUTION.

1.2 The Printing Press Incident (Information Replication Automation)

The printing press allowed one operator to do the work of hundreds of scribes, destroying the medieval manuscript-copying industry at a rate now described as “disruptive.”

Observed consequences:

- Mass unemployment among monks (Manuscript Sector)
- Explosion of literacy (Unexpected Externality)
- Scientific Revolution (Unplanned Feature)
- Newspapers (Mixed Results)

Economic theory response: The Industrial Revolution.

EXHIBIT A-2
THE PRINTING PRESS:
UNFAIR REPLICATION DEVICE

DANGER:
INFORMATION MULTIPLICATION
BEYOND HUMAN CONTROL

SCRIBES UNION
LOCAL 14C:
DOWN WITH
UNFAIR MACHINES!

LATE ARRIVING EXPERTS
(ALWAYS)

- OBSERVED TOO LATE
- FILED LENGTHY REPORTS
- WON NOBEL PRIZES
RETROSPECTIVELY

BUREAU OF HISTORICAL
RISK ASSESSMENT
“HINDSIGHT IS OUR MANDATE”

WARNING:
HISTORY IS FULL OF MACHINES
WE FAILED TO PANIC ABOUT.
DO NOT REPEAT THIS MISTAKE.



IF WE DON'T REMEMBER HISTORY, WE ARE CONDEMNED TO REDECLARE IT DANGEROUS.

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**HISTORY
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DANGER
DECLARED.**

1.3 The Steam Engine Overreaction (Mechanical Labor Replacement)

The steam engine replaced:

- Human muscle
- Animal muscle
- Water wheels
- Windmills
- Entire professions involving pulling ropes very slowly

This resulted in factories, railways, global trade, and economists becoming a permanent feature of society.



AT THE TIME,
OBSERVERS STATED:

**“Machines will
take all the jobs.”**

— Everyone, 1820

Employment subsequently
increased for the next
200 years.

EXHIBIT: STEAM ENGINE
(c. 1769–)



ALERT! ALERT! ALERT!
HISTORICAL OBJECTS UNDER REVIEW

FACTORIES



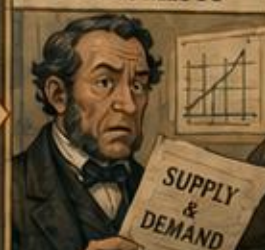
RAILWAYS



GLOBAL TRADE



ECONOMISTS



DANGER!
MASS LABOR
REPLACEMENT DEVICE

1.4 The Tractor Catastrophe (Agricultural Labor Collapse)

In 1800, ~80–90% of humans
worked in agriculture.

Today, in developed economies:
~1–2%.

If the claim “machines that do
weeks of human work in minutes
break economics” were true,
the invention of the tractor
should have ended civilization
immediately. Instead, it
produced cities, universities,
and professional podcasts.



EXHIBIT: TRACTOR
(c. 1890–)



DANGER!
RURAL EMPLOYMENT
DISPLACEMENT DEVICE

CITIES



UNIVERSITIES



GLOBAL FOOD ABUNDANCE



PROFESSIONAL PODCASTS



BUREAU OF HISTORICAL
RISK ASSESSMENT
“HINDSIGHT IS OUR MANDATE”

EMERGENCY HEARING
DOCKET 47-B-

**BACKDATED
HAZARD**

SUBJECT: OLD INVENTIONS
EVENT: BENEFICIAL
TO DATE

! JOB
THEFT
RISK

! PRODUCTIVITY
OVERLOAD
RISK

! PROGRESS
SPIRAL
RISK

! UNNATURAL
FORWARD
MOMENTUM

TESTIMONY
VOLUME C

**EXHIBIT
C**

IF WE DON'T REMEMBER HISTORY, WE ARE CONDEMNED TO REDECLARE IT DANGEROUS.



INSTITUTE FOR RETROACTIVE TECHNOLOGICAL PANIC (IRTP)

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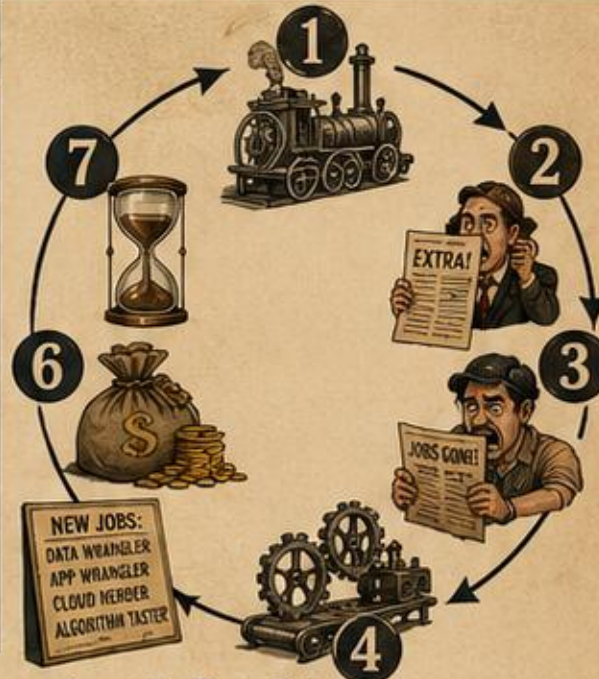
HISTORY
REASSESSD.
DANGER
DECLARED.

2. METHODOLOGY: THE RECURRING PANIC MODEL (RPM)

The Institute proposes the following model:

Technological Panic Cycle (TPC):

- 1 New machine appears
- 2 Commentators declare it unprecedented
- 3 Commentators declare all jobs will disappear
- 4 Productivity increases
- 5 New jobs appear that sound fake
- 6 Society becomes richer
- 7 Repeat with new machine



This cycle has been repeating since approximately Fire v1.0.

We therefore introduce the core equation of technological panic:

$$\text{Panic} = (\text{Speed of Machine} \times \text{Media Attention}) \div \text{Historical Memory}$$

Where Historical Memory is typically near zero.

★ 3. PERSONNEL ★

	Name	Title	Qualifications
	Dr. Archibald Steamwright	Chief Historian of Obvious Things	PhD, Industrial Revolutions (1-3)
	Prof. Eleanor Gutenberg II	Director of Previously Solved Problems	Printed 14,000 books to prove a point
	Sir Reginald Combustion	Chair of Fire Studies	Discovered fire already existed
	Dr. Ada Calculon	Lead Researcher, Things That Calculate Faster Than Humans	Repeatedly shocked by calculators
	Mr. Thomas The Tractor	Senior Fellow, Agricultural Job Apocalypse That Already Happened	Replaced 400 farmhands personally
	Committee for Remembering the Steam Engine	Advisory Board	Meets annually, ignored consistently

RETROACTIVE
THREAT LEVEL:

SEVERE

ALARM IN EFFECT

★ MUSEUM OF
QUESTIONABLE
PROGRESS

EST. 1857

ALERT! ALERT! ALERT!
HISTORICAL OBJECTS UNDER REVIEW

CURRENT CRISIS DIAGRAM:
OLD INVENTIONS,
NEW PROBLEMS

TELEGRAPHS
CAUSE ANXIETY

TIMEPIECES
DISRUPT NOW

TYPEWRITERS
THREATEN
ORIGINAL
THOUGHT

STEAM
ENGINES
VIOLATE
NATURAL
SPEED

CAUTION:

INVENTIONS FROM THE PAST
MAY TRAVEL TOO FAR
INTO THE FUTURE

STAFF DOSSIER

— INTERNAL USE ONLY —



Clearance Level: **SEVERE**

Employee Reminder:

**DOUBT PROGRESS.
DOCUMENT PANIC.
JUSTIFY EXISTENCE.**

Robert
Director of Bureaucratic Continuity

BUREAU OF HISTORICAL
RISK ASSESSMENT
"HINDSIGHT IS OUR MANDATE"

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HISTORY
REASSESSED.
DANGER
DECLARED.

THE PAST
IS NOW
A LIABILITY

EXHIBITS
MAY CAUSE:

- CONTEMPLATION
- INDEPENDENT
THOUGHT
- SPECULATION
- PROGRESS

PROCEED WITH CAUTION.

★ 4. BUDGET ALLOCATION ★

Item	Cost	Justification
Archival research proving the steam engine existed	\$2,400,000	Controversial claim
Public awareness campaign: "The Printing Press Already Happened"	\$1,800,000	Literacy enabling
Fire demonstration grant	\$950,000	Pilot program
Emergency Historical Memory Reserve	\$3,200,000	For future panics
Consultant economists to rediscover tractors	\$4,600,000	Ongoing
Administrative overhead	\$7,900,000	Essential
Coffee	\$480,000	Non-optional
Contingency fund in case someone invents a new machine and everyone loses their minds again	\$12,000,000	Highly likely

Total Budget: \$33,330,000

RETROACTIVE
THREAT LEVEL:

SEVERE

ALARM IN EFFECT

MUSEUM OF
QUESTIONABLE
PROGRESS
EST. 1857

OLD IDEAS.
NEW RISKS.
EXPENSIVE
SOLUTIONS.

POTENTIAL LIABILITIES

STEAM ENGINE
(c. 1769)

PRINTING PRESS
(c. 1440)

TRACTOR
(c. ???)

HANDLE ONLY WITH
BUDGET AUTHORIZATION

UNEXPECTED
INVENTIONS
CONTINGENCY
FILES

IRTP BUREAU OF FUNDING RATIONALIZATION
APPROPRIATION REQUEST
Form IRTP-27B (Rev. Panic)

APPROVED IN FEAR

SIGNATURE: *[Signature]*

DATE: ALWAYS

FISCAL PANIC
JUSTIFIED

FUTURE PANICS
FUNDING
PROJECTIONS

TOP SECRET
(UNTIL NEEDED)

EMERGENCY
APPROPRIATIONS
LEDGER

**OVERFUNDED
BUT NECESSARY**

BUREAU OF HISTORICAL
RISK ASSESSMENT
"HINDSIGHT IS OUR MANDATE"



SPEND NOW.
PANIC LATER.
(REPEAT AS
NECESSARY.)

ACCOUNTS DIVISION
MAKING NUMBERS
FEEL SAFER

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IF WE DON'T FUND IT, AND IT TURNS OUT TO BE DANGEROUS...
WE WILL DEFINITELY NEED MORE FUNDING.



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★ 5. CONCLUSION ★

After extensive research, the Institute concludes that machines doing the work of many humans very quickly is not a new phenomenon, does not break economics, and has in fact been the main driver of rising living standards since the invention of tools, agriculture, and not dying at age 30.

However, despite this conclusion, the Institute simultaneously recommends immediate and total panic, as this time is clearly different, for reasons to be determined later.

END OF WHITE PAPER



FINAL HEARING
IN PROGRESS
(PANIC REQUIRED)

EMERGENCY HEARING
DOCKET 47-B

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE POSITION:
PANIC NOW, ANALYZE LATER



FINAL RECOMMENDATION:
☒ IMMEDIATE PANIC
☐ WAIT AND SEE
(IRRESPONSIBLE)

FUTURE REASON:
"THIS TIME IS
DIFFERENT"

PLACEHOLDER
ARCHIVE
(MAYBE)

HEARING
CLOSED
PANIC
LOCKED IN

TEARS OF
HINDSIGHT

Institute for Retroactive Technological Panic (IRTP)

— "Remembering Things So You Don't Have To." —

IF WE DON'T REMEMBER HISTORY, WE ARE CONDEMNED TO REDECLARE IT DANGEROUS.

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RETROACTIVE
THREAT LEVEL:

SEVERE

ALARM IN EFFECT

MUSEUM OF
QUESTIONABLE
PROGRESS
EST. 1857

ALERT! ALERT! ALERT!
ALL OLD INVENTIONS NOW DANGEROUS

PLOWS
(c. 3000 BCE)

PRINTING PRESS
(c. 1440)

STEAM ENGINE
(c. 1769)

RISK: MASS
DISPLACEMENT
MAY ENABLE
PEOPLE TO EAT

RISK: INFORMATION
MULTIPLICATION
MAY LEAD TO
IDEAS

RISK: POWER
CONCENTRATION
MAY RESULT IN
INDUSTRY

EXPERTS ARRIVING
TOO LATE
(AGAIN)